

Chapter 111-2: Gathering

Six Roots Magnificent Adornment Island was located high above the clouds, so even if there was misty rain below the island, once you climbed onto it, there would be clear skies for thousands of miles.

Since this island served as a trading place for all immortal sect members, all the decorations on the island were a mixture from various places. There were pink walls with black tiles, Buddhist walls and temple courtyards, as well as jade towers and Western Region ancient buildings—a different scene with each step, a different city with each step.

During the Immortal-Demon Conference, countless cultivators swarmed onto the island, packing the vast territory so tightly that not even water could leak through. The inns and wine houses had long been fully occupied, and some wanderers without sects who wanted to join the excitement simply rested on the streets, creating extreme chaos for a time.

However, don't let the mixed crowd elsewhere fool you—the Alchemy Cauldron Manor at the island's center was heavily guarded, already hung with lanterns and red candles early on, preparing to host the banquet for all immortal sects during the Demon Extermination Conference.

This place was originally the largest trading location on Six Roots Magnificent Adornment Island. It was shaped like a complete circle with a high platform at the center, while the surroundings were like ordinary wine houses, divided into regular customer and VIP areas. Below were layered tables and chairs for people to sit and recline, while above was a circle of floating pavilions for VIP use.

The Alchemy Cauldron Manor belonged to the Gongsun family of Guangling¹, so it was designed like a painted pleasure boat. Around the circular platform was clear river water with floating flower lanterns in the water, making everyone feel as if they were wandering in a river.

The top had no canopy, using the natural stars and galaxy as a roof, so one could see the Big Dipper and Milky Way when looking up.

At this moment, the doors opened and everyone entered through the main gate. When they stepped inside, they all let out exclamations of admiration, especially those junior disciples who were visiting for the first time, chattering and marveling endlessly.

Liu Wenzhu and several others led the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate disciples to sit at one side of the high platform. From time to time, immortal servants came carrying plates, setting down delicacies and fruits while gently saying "please enjoy."

Elder Pingyao and Elder Jingshan sat at the highest position, both with solemn expressions, while the Chief Elder beside them had fallen asleep again, his snoring resounding earth-shakingly.

The female disciple Tao Tao with her sky-high braids sat down beside Liu Wenzhu. She had grown much taller over the years, but her hair remained unchanged, still standing out conspicuously.

She said excitedly: "Wenzhu, Wenzhu, where is the Divine Venerable?"

"The Divine Venerable's health hasn't been good since awakening, and she doesn't like noise. She should be in the upper pavilion now." Liu Wenzhu looked up as she spoke, and indeed, several points of light were shining in the highest pavilion.

"Sigh, I wonder what the Divine Venerable's feelings were when she woke up and heard about what happened thirty years ago. After all, she was quite caring toward Ning Fuyi, more loving than she was to us." Tao Tao poked her cheek as she spoke.

"That demon head wouldn't really come, would she?" a unfamiliar young disciple came over and said. "I heard from fellow disciples that she used to be from our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. She won't implicate us, will she?"

"Xiang Yushan, be quiet." Feng Ge, who had been silent, spoke coldly, interrupting his words.

The young disciple stuck out his tongue and shrank back, discussing in low voices with several other newly admitted North Garden disciples: "We're always forbidden from mentioning the name Ning Fuyi. She's just a demon head who betrayed her sect—why be so secretive about it?"

"Keep your voice down. This Ning Fuyi used to be good friends with Senior Sister Wenzhu and Senior Brother Rong Jin. Discussing this in front of them—aren't you asking for trouble?" another disciple said.

Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin exchanged glances but didn't speak.

Instead, deliberately loud laughter came from nearby. Several people turned to look and saw it was Hua Feiwu from the Flying Flower Sect again. He was sitting cross-legged in the best position, holding a sweet melon and gnawing on it.

"How unlucky, why do we always run into him?" Feng Ge said in a low voice, turning his head away to avoid looking.

Hearing that voice, Rong Jin clenched his fists again, hating that he had lost his cultivation and could only endure the bullying without being able to fight back.

"What are you laughing at?" Liu Wenzhu squeezed the words out through gritted teeth.

Hua Feiwu propped up his head and turned toward her, his eyes looking her up and down: "What, is the Liu family's young lady now managing our Flying Flower Sect too?"

"If you ask me, that whatever-her-name-is Ning person simply doesn't dare appear. With her little bit of cultivation, forget about Penglai—even if she fell into our Flying Flower Sect's hands, she couldn't escape." Hua Feiwu drawled.

Hearing him being so arrogant, Liu Wenzhu really couldn't bear it anymore. She clenched her fists and suddenly stood up, but saw that Hua Feiwu seemed to have seen something that frightened him. He covered his neck and shrank under the table.

But he was quickly grabbed by a hand and pressed down onto the table, whimpering: "Elder brother, elder brother, I was wrong, I was wrong! Don't hit my face!"

The hand grabbing him had distinct joints and was very strong, with faint calluses on the fingertips. However, the skin was fine, white, and tender, somewhat androgynous.

Liu Wenzhu dissolved the thousand-jin hammer in her hand and glared angrily at the two of them.

The one grabbing Hua Feiwu was a very handsome man with a tall figure. Though it was spring, he wore a cloak, seemingly to conceal his thinness.

Liu Wenzhu had seen this person before, in Qi State, brought by her father Liu Wenhai. At that time, she was only focused on the Female Emperor's mission and hadn't looked closely. Only now did she find him familiar.

"Apologize to Miss Liu." The man said in a deep voice that was much more pleasant than an ordinary man's, matching his face.

Though Hua Feiwu appeared arrogant and domineering, he was actually a coward in front of his elder brother, saying in a shrill voice: "Sorry, sorry, sorry, sorry!"

Seeing that people in the distance were all looking this way, Liu Wenzhu didn't want to attract too much attention, so she sat back down without saying a word.

Finally, she glanced at the man again. The man wasn't looking at her but was lowering his head to scold Hua Feiwu, his profile delicate with long eyelashes.

Liu Wenzhu let out a breath, and Rong Jin beside her suddenly pulled at her and said: "That's Hua Feihua, the young sect leader of the Flying Flower Sect. His temperament is very different from Hua Feiwu's—he's gentle and mild, quite outstanding in their sect."

"I heard he's going to take over the Flying Flower Sect in the future." Rong Jin said softly.

"Just another annoying man. What does it have to do with me?" Liu Wenzhu said gently.

Rong Jin smiled.

The chaos below could be seen clearly by those in the pavilions above.

Besides the pavilions where the various sect leaders were located, there were two other pavilions that were the most mysterious. One was tightly covered by curtains, not letting out a bit of light, while the other was like a gorgeous painted pleasure boat on the banks of the Qinhuai River², constantly emitting melodious music, with continuous laughter inside that stirred the imagination.

Across from these two pavilions, a single lantern shone lonely under the eaves, with gauze curtains covering half of it. Inside the curtains, a silhouette was cast—a woman sitting upright with white robes layered in heaps at her feet.

She held a white jade hairpin in her hand, seeming to be lost in thought.

A knock at the door interrupted her thoughts. Chu Qingqiu reflexively hid the hairpin and looked toward the door with her peach blossom eyes.

A small immortal servant in a green dress walked to the door, received a bowl of soup, then walked back with lotus steps: "Divine Venerable, this is the special tea soup of the Alchemy Cauldron Manor, made with mortal realm medicinal herbs. You..."

"No need. I don't like medicinal herbs." The woman spoke with her usual tone.

"This tea soup is really good. Please try it..."

The small immortal servant was young and didn't know how to read expressions. She actually opened her mouth to persuade again, but suddenly the soup bowl in her hand exploded, scalding her into continuous screams.

She immediately knelt down: "Divine Venerable, please calm your anger. This humble one didn't know the Divine Venerable was so averse..."

Chu Qingqiu was also surprised that she momentarily couldn't contain her intimidating aura. She hurriedly stood up wanting to help, but seeing the immortal servant's trembling shoulders, she drew her hand back into her sleeves.

"Sorry, this venerable didn't mean it." She said in a low voice, then waved her long sleeve over the servant's hand, and the redness disappeared.

She paused, then said: "It's not your fault. You may go. I don't need anyone to serve me."

The small immortal servant hurriedly apologized several more times before slowly escaping. Chu Qingqiu pressed her lips together, a trace of fragility flashing in her eyes.

Ever since returning from that heavy snow, she always felt cold, so she hugged her arms tightly and stood by the gauze curtain, looking through the blurry curtain at the vast sea of people and lights below—heads bobbing, chaotic and lively.

Had Ning Fuyi come?

Where was she?

Footnotes:

1. **Guangling:** An ancient Chinese place name, referring to what is now Yangzhou in Jiangsu Province. The Gongsun family appears to be a powerful merchant or noble family from this region.
2. **Qinhuai River:** A famous river in Nanjing known for its pleasure boats and entertainment district, especially during imperial China. The reference evokes luxury and sophistication.